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A Systemic view of Meetings – Windows on Organization Collective Minding

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Abstract

Treating meetings collectively as a unit of analysis enables a holistic view of their theoretical foundations, their practical operation and potential contribution to organization. Concepts are drawn from systems and process thinking, sensemaking and sensegiving, and organizational collective mind to inform a systemic conceptualization of organizational meetings. A systemic conceptualization of organizational meetings sees meetings as interconnected elements in an ongoing process of organizational sensemaking, rather than as discrete or isolated events. Supported by data from over 60 meetings in one organization, a Systemic Meetings Model is developed incorporating retrospective and prehensive sensemaking as the principal categories of connections between past, present and future meetings. A systemic perspective on meetings views them as an integrated whole, but also as a process of connected events unfolding in time. The emergent organizational process is termed collective minding, requiring greater mindfulness of how meetings are deployed and increased heedfulness of how they are interconnected in practice. Collective minding accounts for how meetings systemically manifest, contribute to and sustain collective mind over time in organizations.

Key words: Systemic thinking, Process thinking, Sensemaking, Sensegiving, Collective Mind, Systemic Meetings Model.

Introduction

Meetings are perhaps one of the most ubiquitous activities in organizations. A considerable body of research has been carried out across multiple disciplines, focused on meetings as a research resource (Dittrich, Guerard, & Seidl, 2011). Yet meetings as the topic of research themselves were, for a long time, under-researched (Boden, 1994; Schwartzman, 1989; Scott, Shanock, & Rogelberg, 2011). More recently there has been a welcome increase in studying meetings from various perspectives, many of which are well-represented in this volume. This chapter focuses on an often neglected aspect of meetings: the way in which meetings relate to each other as collective rather than isolated episodes of interaction. This means that we look at how meetings (taken collectively) work together, rather than focusing on the working or impact of individual meetings. Unusually then, meetings collectively is the unit of analysis in this chapter.

The chapter is organized into six main sections. Following this introduction, section two provides a short theoretical background to support the systemic perspective being adopted. Necessarily this requires some explanations of special terms that are generally familiar to those with an organizational system perspective but may be new to readers from other disciplines. The third section briefly introduces the reader to KT-Inc., the source of the research data. The data analysis highlights key ways in which meetings are connected to each other, which are used to inform and develop a systemic meetings model. Section four provides a summary of the development of the systemic perspective on meetings, using a series of figures to illustrate increasingly rich versions of the systemic meetings model. The model is informed by literature on sensemaking and illustrated by examples from the KT-Inc. data. The fifth section draws out some of the practical implications that may arise from adopting a systemic perspective on

meetings. The final section summarizes the ideas presented on meetings and the implications of treating them as a collective organizational phenomenon.

Theoretical foundations

Systemic, Processual and Communicative Perspectives

Using the word ‘system’ may cause initial confusion, orienting some readers towards IT, computers or information systems. We use the word ‘system’ in the more general sense as developed in systems theory. Von Bertalanffy (1969) viewed general systems theory as a “broad view” representing “scientific exploration of "wholes" and "wholeness" (preface). Checkland and Scholes (1999) describe this as ‘holonic thinking’ and use the phrase ‘holon’ to describe “... a whole having emergent properties, a layered structure and processes of communication and control which in principle enable it to survive in a changing environment.” (p. 22). The interrelated concepts of emergence, layered structure, process, and communication are important to adopting a systemic perspective and are discussed in the next paragraphs.

In the context of systems theory, the concept of ‘emergence’, emphasizes that a whole system produces outputs that individual components cannot produce alone. Emergent outputs then come to characterize or identify the system as a whole (Checkland & Scholes, 1999, p. 22; Meadows, 2009, p. 12; von Bertalanffy, 1969, p. 55). The concepts of layered structure and the process of communication are important contributors to emergence and emergent outputs from a system.

A layered structure describes the hierarchy within a system. However, this hierarchy is not necessarily denoted by authoritarian top-down relationships (Checkland & Scholes, 1999, p. 19) but may be formed by layers building up to form the whole system. Meadows (2009, p. 85) explains this as a layering of sub-systems within each other, which are conceptually similar to

Boden's (1994) "lamination" (p. 91). Lamination refers to contributions forming layers within organizations, which viewed collectively, represent essential constitutive elements of the organization. From a systems perspective, hierarchy could thus be viewed as evolving from the bottom up, with the upper layers built upon and serving the purposes of the lower layers – an inversion of the conventional view of hierarchy as a top-down arrangement.

Process can be defined as "a sequence of individual and collective events, actions, and activities unfolding over time in context" (Pettigrew, 1997, p. 38). Tsoukas (1996) points out that an emergent property of an organization can come into being "as individual contributions become more heedfully interrelated in time". The temporal dimension essential to and stressed by process ontology (Hernes, 2014; Langley, 2009; Langley & Tsoukas, 2010) is not always explicit within systems thinking. Of the features overlapping systems and processual thinking, temporal inter-connectedness is the weakest and holistic explanation the strongest. Tsoukas' reference to heedful interrelating will be explored more fully in the next section dealing with sensemaking.

Communication does not always just reference reality but can at times act to constitute it, especially those aspects of reality to which humans address themselves and their actions. Far from requiring a mystical view of how reality is formed, the productive power of communication or discourse can be seen in how a company's identity is created in a practical sense, beyond the legal status acquired through documents lodged in the company registration office. Such discourse names those who head the organization and its subunits, creates its strategic and operational practices and controls its processes (Boden, 1994; Schwartzman, 1989; Scott, et al., 2011). The role of discourse in the communicative and control aspects of organizational systems can be explored using tools created, adopted and adapted by the Communicative Constitution of

Organization (CCO) approach (Cooren, Kuhn, Cornelissen, & Clark, 2011; McPhee & Zaug, 2000, 2009; Schoeneborn, 2011; Taylor & Van Every, 2000).

By taking a systemic view of meetings, they are seen as an essential and influential component in the discourse processes that flow through and constitute organizations. As processes of communication unfold through time, meetings could be envisaged as a "flow of events"(Hernes, 2014, p. 42), with time structuring meetings as an integrated process in the same way gravity structures the flow of water. Organizations can be viewed as a "river of discourse" (Duffy & O'Rourke, 2012b, p. 2), a metaphor reflecting how multiple and intersecting organizational discourses connect meetings to each other and how meetings recursively (Giddens, 1984, Introduction xxiii) connect organizational discourses. Figure 1 illustrates this metaphor and shows how meetings integrate with processes of organizational discourse.

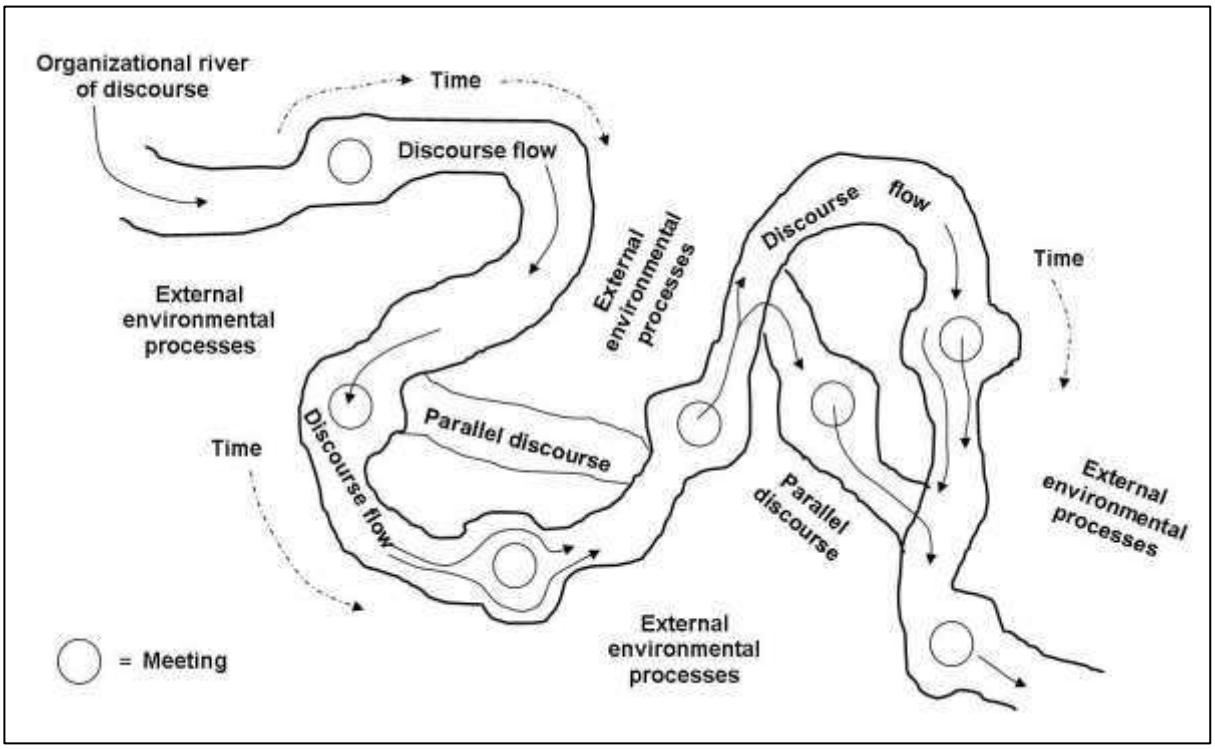

Figure 1 – An organizational river of discourse.

Sensemaking

Sensemaking refers to the processes of retention, selection and enactment that help to create organization (Weick, 1979). As reflected in Weick's (1979) seminal rhetorical question *"*How can I know what I think until I see what I say?*"* (p. 133), 'talk' is the basic sensemaking device to discover thinking (1979, p. 166) and creates consensually validated enacted environments (1979, p. 250). Such sensemaking has been researched in a diverse range of organizational contexts such as organizational change (Balogun & Johnson, 2005; Gioia & Chittipeddi, 1991), industrial accidents (Weick, 1988, 1990), natural disasters (Weick, 1993), medical misadventure (Weick & Sutcliffe, 2009) and managerial identity (Gioia & Thomas, 1996; Rouleau & Balogun, 2011). In addition to these diverse studies on sensemaking, both Boden (1994, 1997) and Schwartzman (1986, 1989) clearly see meetings as essential events combining organizational talk and sensemaking.

Sensegiving: a species of sensemaking

Sensegiving is a widely recognized variant of sensemaking, aimed at creating meaning for a target audience (Weick, Sutcliffe, & Obstfeld, 2005). As part of an overall sensemaking process, the purpose of sensegiving is to influence the sensemaking of others and how they construct their meaning. It is also characterized by steering individuals towards "a preferred redefinition of organizational reality" (Gioia & Chittipeddi, 1991, p. 442). Sensegiving generally operates as a mechanism for organizational leaders to influence colleagues and guide their sensemaking in a specific direction, on a particular topic. Sensegiving is also part of an inter-play between various organizational actors, either reinforcing sense already made or calling it into question and causing it to be revised.

Retrospective versus Prehensive Sensemaking

Weick (1995) considers sensemaking a predominantly retrospective process based on the premise that sense can only be made of something after it has already happened. This view of sensemaking as a retrospective activity seems to be widely accepted, or at least not explicitly challenged, in much of the sensemaking literature (Maitlis, 2005; Maitlis & Lawrence, 2007; Rouleau & Balogun, 2011; Weick, 1995, 2001; Weick, et al., 2005). In this chapter, retrospective sensemaking is the activity of making sense in the present by reference to past meetings.

In contrast to Weick's focus on retrospection, Bourdieu (1990) emphasizes "the absurdity of a future-less, and therefore senseless, present" (p. 82). To stress that sensemaking comprises not only retrospective but also prospective dimensions, we use and adapt the concept of "prehension", which Hernes (2014) suggests "relates to the propensity of an event to connect to another event with which it has common aims" (p. 159).

Prehensive sensemaking (Duffy & O'Rourke, 2013), as an adaptation of prehension, is defined as taking steps in the present to deliberately inform a sensemaking process in the future. Schwartzman (1989, p. 9) considered sensemaking to be an integral part of all organizational meetings. In the context of a systemic view of meetings, prehensive sensemaking may arise in meetings as a natural anticipation of sensemaking that will inevitably take place in future meetings. Using prehensive sensemaking would reflect a disposition towards meetings as a systemic sensemaking process. It would inform thinking and discourse in meetings (in the present) to ensure appropriate 'transportation' (Cooren, Matte, Taylor, & Vasquez, 2007) of ideas or information into future meetings, to support future sensemaking processes.

It might be helpful to make clear why prehensive sensemaking is not the same as sensegiving. Prehensive sensemaking does not have the reciprocity of sensegiving that might

occur in an individual meeting. In a meeting, recipients of sensegiving may respond to the 'sensegiver', leading to feedback into the sensemaking taking place (Weick, et al., 2005, p. 416); where such sensegiving may alter based on the reaction of the receiver, prehensive sensemaking cannot be altered in response to the future which, given time's arrow, it cannot know. By definition, prehensive sensemaking is informed by anticipated needs in an unpredictable future, but the output of prehensive sensemaking cannot be altered once received at some future time.

In contrast to the broader concept of sensemaking previously reported in the literature, the emerging sensemaking process proposed in this chapter reflects the combined concepts of retrospective sensemaking and future oriented prehensive sensemaking, applied in the context of a systemic meetings model. This is represented in Figure 2.

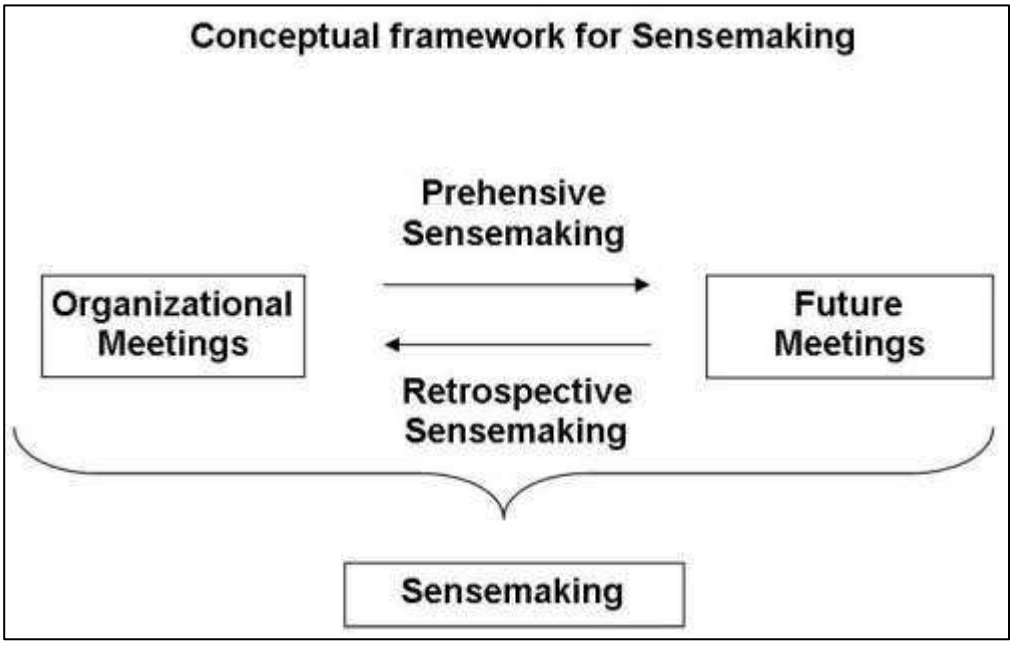

Figure 2 - Prehensive and retrospective sensemaking.

Collective Mind and Minding.

For readers familiar with literatures on idealism, materialism or consciousness, the term 'mind' may be problematic and referring to a 'collective mind' or 'collective minding' may significantly increase the number of those who might be so troubled. However, our use of collective mind and collective minding does not engage with many of the ontological concerns of such debates. Mind is used in the sense defined by Weick and Roberts (1993) as "a propensity to act in a certain manner or style" (p. 361). Again, following Weick and Roberts (1993), the term 'collective' is used in preference to 'group' or 'organization', to refer to individuals whose actions join together to make a collective action but who remain as individuals. Three key components combine to account for both the existence and degree of collective mind in an organization: mindfulness, heedfulness and the nature and degree of interconnections between distributed organizational activities.

Mindfulness refers to the degree to which premeditation informs activity. It focuses on self awareness of both individuals and groups, emphasizing the quality of the attention being paid and its ongoing sustainability (Weick, Sutcliffe, & Obstfeld, 1999, p. 37). In this context, mindfulness is not a passive activity but is determined by the nature of activity within the organization. Activity is necessary but not sufficient for mindfulness to be present. Premeditated thought and intent are the other key elements

Heedfulness refers to the mutual awareness that exists between constituent parts of a system or organization. It is not a static attribute but an ongoing disposition and approach to inter-relating between system elements. Collective mind "…inheres in the pattern of interrelated activities among many people" (Weick & Roberts, 1993, p. 360). Where mindfulness might be considered the conceptual foundation of collective mind, heedful interrelating represents the

practice foundation on which collective mind is built. The level of heedfulness in interrelations becomes the determinant of the strength of collective mind. With increasing heedfulness, the sense of collective mind improves.

Cooren (2004) coined the term "collective minding" to describe how interactive talk in meetings could act as a process exhibiting the characteristics of a collective mind, and more specifically accounting for how such collective mind might be accomplished. He focused on the process of how collective mind arises. Using "patterns of conversational behavior" (2004, p. 518) within a single meeting, Cooren argued the patterns he identified displayed an organizational collective mind. The combined micro level conversational processes routinely taking place in an organization's board meeting are then advanced as examples of collective minding (2004, p. 519).

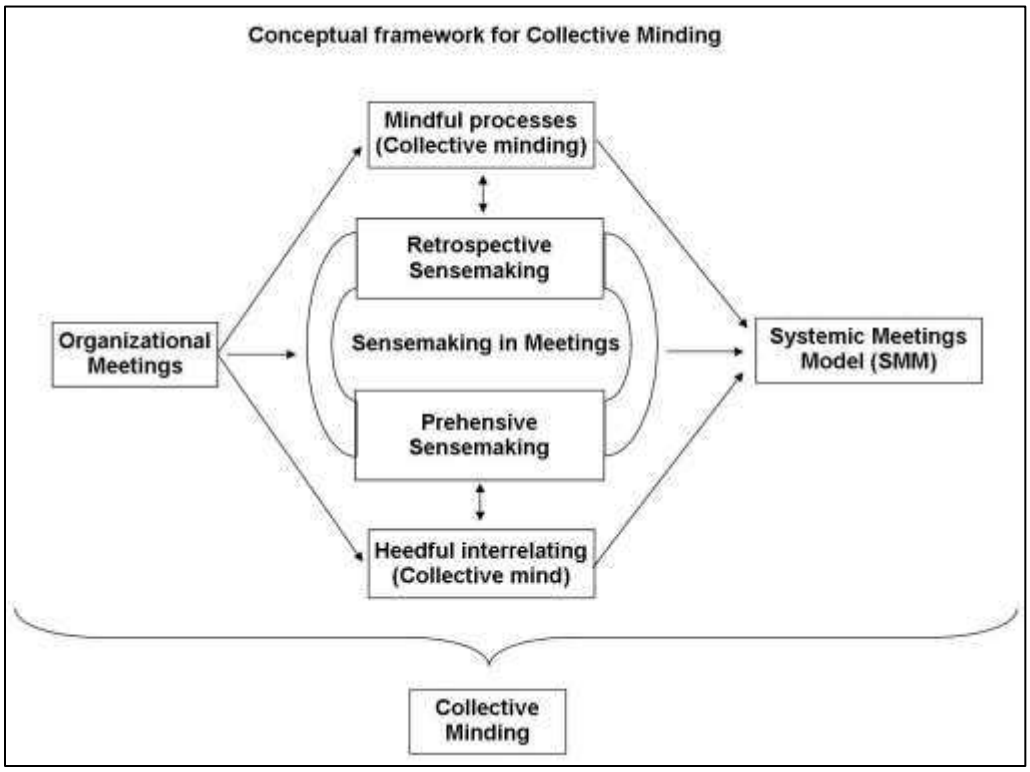

Figure 3 - Conceptual framework for collective minding.

We use the term collective minding to describe an emergent (systemic) output of processes that create, sustain or develop mindfulness about and heedful interrelating between an organization's meetings. Figure 3 provides an overview of how the various concepts concerning meetings introduced so far, and the Systemic Meetings Model to be introduced in the next section, relate to each other and contribute to our understanding of collective minding.

The Case of KT-Inc

The Systemic Meetings Model offered in this chapter is grounded in an extensive data set collected in a company referred to as KT-Inc. While the data was being collected, KT-Inc was undergoing significant organizational change and placed considerable emphasis on strategic planning. More specific points of focus for their meeting agendas were product development, new market development, consolidation of partnerships with resellers, organization restructuring and internal staff and management development. However, the data collection focused on meetings collectively rather than on particular topics being addressed in particular meetings.

The data comprise 160+ hours of recordings of live meetings, covering an 18 month period. The meetings range from two monthly board meetings to weekly operations meetings, in a company of approximately 70 staff. Sixty three meetings in total were attended, covering at least six distinct groups (meeting flows) within the organization. The minutes and agendas for many of the board meetings were also available as supporting reference data. Table 1 illustrates the longitudinal nature of the data and the groups from which the data was recorded.

Groups	Number of meetings	Total meeting time recorded	
Board	10	48:55:00	**Meetings took place between** **15th February 2011** **and** **17th July 2013**
Resellers & Retail team	8	34:45:00	
Exports team	5	29:35:00	
Operations team	22	21:50:00	
Marketing forum	2	7:20:00	
Management Team	6	5:21:00	
Meetings with individual managers	3	4:15:00	
Strategy workshop (Senior managers)	1	4:05:00	
Officers group (Exec Directors - GM/ Fin/ Mkting/ Ops)	1	2:00:00	
Resellers special initiative	1	2:00:00	
Industrial Products team	1	0:55:00	
Special Project Group	1	0:55:00	
General staff briefing	1	0:30:00	
Resellers special training meeting	1	0:30:00	
Managers meetings PMI	2	1:10:00	
Total	**63**	**162:56:00**	

Table 1 – Summary of the data set.

A Systemic Perspective from KT-Inc - Connections Between Meetings

This section briefly outlines the types of connections between meetings that were identified in the data collected in KT-Inc.

Trans-participants

‘Trans-participants’ reflects a category of meeting participants who attend the meetings of more than one group (Duffy & O'Rourke, 2012a, 2012b). They act as one form of communicative bridge between the meetings of different groups. Where discrete groups have

their own periodic meetings, trans-participants represent a means of connection between groups. Trans-participants are a means of communication as well as a potential means of control, communicated across meetings. Analysis of the data identified at least four managers in KT-Inc who were considered trans-participants, operating at various levels of influence across the meeting flows of different groups as illustrated in Figure 4.

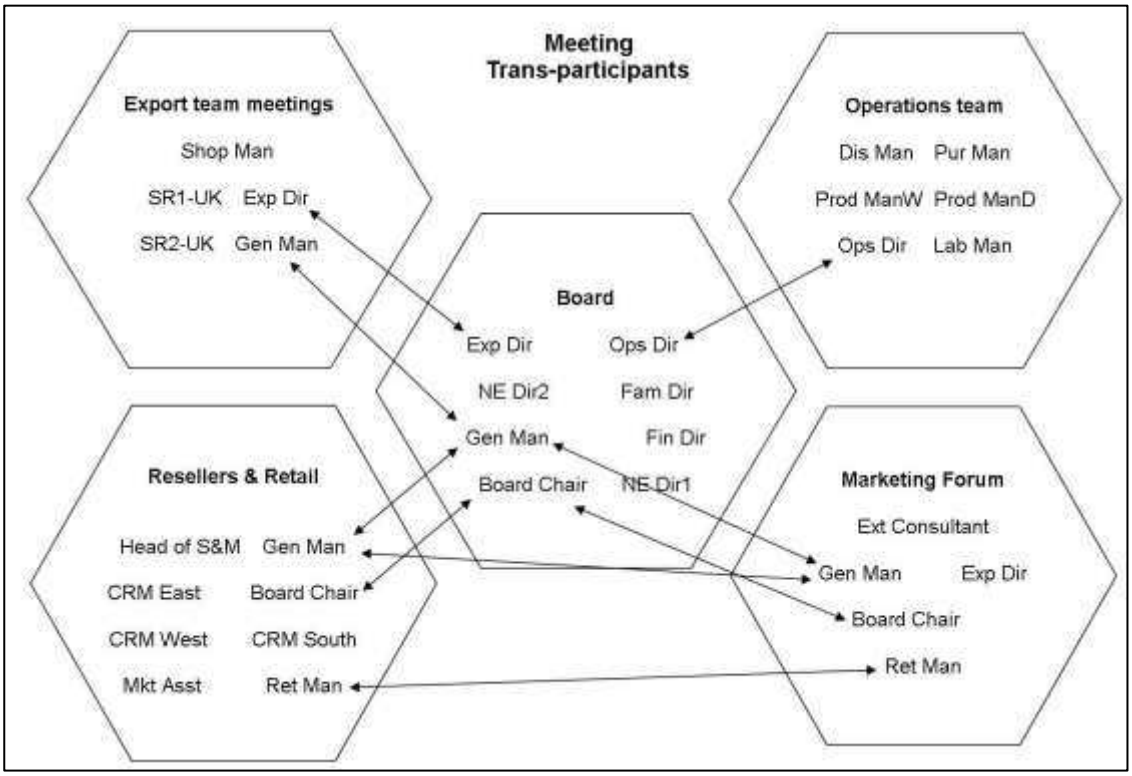

Figure 4 - Meeting trans-participants.

The potential roles of trans-participants can vary, depending on their status or position in the organization, the number of different groups' meetings they attend and the level of influence they exert. Additional factors such as the topics they raise or how other participants react to them could provide a basis for identifying levels or degrees of trans-participants.

Immutable mobiles

Originally proposed by Latour (2005, p. 223), immutable mobile describes something that can be transported from one place to another without being distorted of changed. Latour's concept was adapted by Cooren et al. (2007) to account for how particular aspects of organizational discourse can transport and preserve meaning across place and time and contribute towards building the essence of an organization. Minutes of meetings might be considered one common and familiar form of an immutable mobile.

In our data, two examples of immutable mobiles are worth highlighting, due to their combination with other means of interconnections to achieve transportation between meetings. The first involves the Managing Director, connecting meetings as a trans-participant, using a PowerPoint presentation of the recently approved company strategic plan (an immutable mobile), delivered at four different meetings of distinct organizational groups. A second example arises at a board meeting on the 26th July 2011, when the newly appointed chairman's first action was to present a plastic-covered page to the board members. The page contained a summary of his management philosophy and was accompanied with a suggestion that it could be used at meetings throughout the company to disseminate this philosophy.

Absent participants

The data supports the idea that someone not physically present at a meeting can be discursively constructed and manifested within meetings. This phenomenon, broadly coming within the scope of what Cooren (2012) calls ventriloquism, is referred to here as 'absent participants'. It is observed in the way meeting participants invoke the views, opinions or pronouncements of people who are not physically present. It is a discursive construction by meeting participants and appears to be used to influence the direction of a discussion, to

reinforce an individual's contribution or to provide information that should be taken into account in the current discussion largely due to its cited origins. It may also be used as a crutch by participants to reinforce their own views or standing within meetings.

The relative power of absent participants lies in the way in which the invoker characterizes the absent-participants' views, the specific issues on which the absent-participant is referenced or the individual who is citing an absent participant. It is important to note at this stage that the absent-participant concept is a behavioral feature initiated and executed by participants at meetings. Further research could provide valuable insights into the prevalence of this behavior in organizations more generally and also the details of the mechanism through which it is enacted.

Control-by-proxy

Unlike the previous concept of absent-participants, individuals who are not present at meetings may also seek to exert their influence or control. They may deliberately or subliminally influence others to carry their message in meetings which they do not attend.

The chairman's management philosophy, preserved on a plastic covered page as referred to earlier, could be considered an example of his efforts to exercise control-by-proxy at meetings he does not attend and more widely throughout the organization. Having documented and distributed his views on team commitments/ behaviors to board members, he finishes with the statement in Exhibit 1.

(0:21:26.8) Board Chairman: So as we sort of, as as I sort of take over as the chairman here those are some thoughts of where I'd be coming from in terms of eh the organization ..... so just a little food for thought for everybody and feel free to cascade down the organization if you think it's appropriate.

Source: KT-Inc Board meeting 26th July 2011

Exhibit 1 – Control-by-proxy

Tracking the content of the plastic covered page through meetings may indicate if it is treated as an immutable mobile and if it successfully achieves some form of control-by-proxy on the part of the new chairman.

The concept of control-by-proxy resembles the previous concept of absent-participants but differs in the individual who invokes and is likely to benefit from the practice - the absentee in the case of control-by-proxy and the individual present in the case of absent-participants. Exercising control or influence will be the common outcome, but achieved by two different individuals, in two different ways, within the same organizational setting.

Clustered artifacts

'Clustered artifacts', as used in this chapter, refers to a collection of texts, documents or activities that provide ways of connecting meetings to each other. As an example, KT-Inc has a written policy on conducting meetings (Artifact 1) which is posted in a number of meeting rooms on its premises. Not surprising is the requirement for each meeting to have an agenda (Artifact 2). Behavioral guidelines (Artifact 3) are provided for meeting conveners and the duties of meeting chairs and participants (Artifact 4) are also set down. Unusually, KT-Inc's policy also states that a review should take place at the end of each meeting (Artifact 5). Together, these form a cluster of five artifacts in KT-Inc. This cluster is invoked each time a meeting is held, thus connecting the meetings in a systemic way, even though some of the artifacts such as the call for a meeting review are often ignored.

Temporal markers

The expression ‘temporal marker’ refers to events or activities that are driven by a prescribed time line or deadline, serving as recognizable punctuation points in the on-going activities of an organization (Duffy & O'Rourke, 2012b). Periodic events such as annual audit, seasonal product demand or calendar year end to name a few, seemed to form part of a temporal drum beat, providing time-related controlling influences across KT-Inc’s meetings. They had the effect of determining both the timing and content of different groups’ meetings and also partially influenced the degree to which some meetings might be explicitly connected to others. Including such markers in a systemic conceptualization of meetings provides an important temporal feature of process (Hernes, 2014) and could guide the optimum timing and co-ordination of meetings to aid communication, control and their overall contribution to the collective mind of an organization.

Systemic Meetings Model

A systemic conceptualization of meetings can be developed into a Systemic Meetings Model (SMM; (Duffy & O'Rourke, 2013). The SMM is an abstracted representation of the connections between meetings as identified during the data analysis and serves as a way to visualize the complexity of those connections over time. The SMM is built around the concepts of time, space, entities and relationships. Examples from the data are used to illustrate the components of the SMM.

Figure 5 illustrates how a number of meetings may take place simultaneously in the present and how a group (B) makes reference to past meetings for the purpose of making sense of something under discussion in their present meeting. The connections to these meetings are characterized as 'direct retrospective' because they involve meetings of the same group and the participants in the current and previous meeting(s) are largely the same.

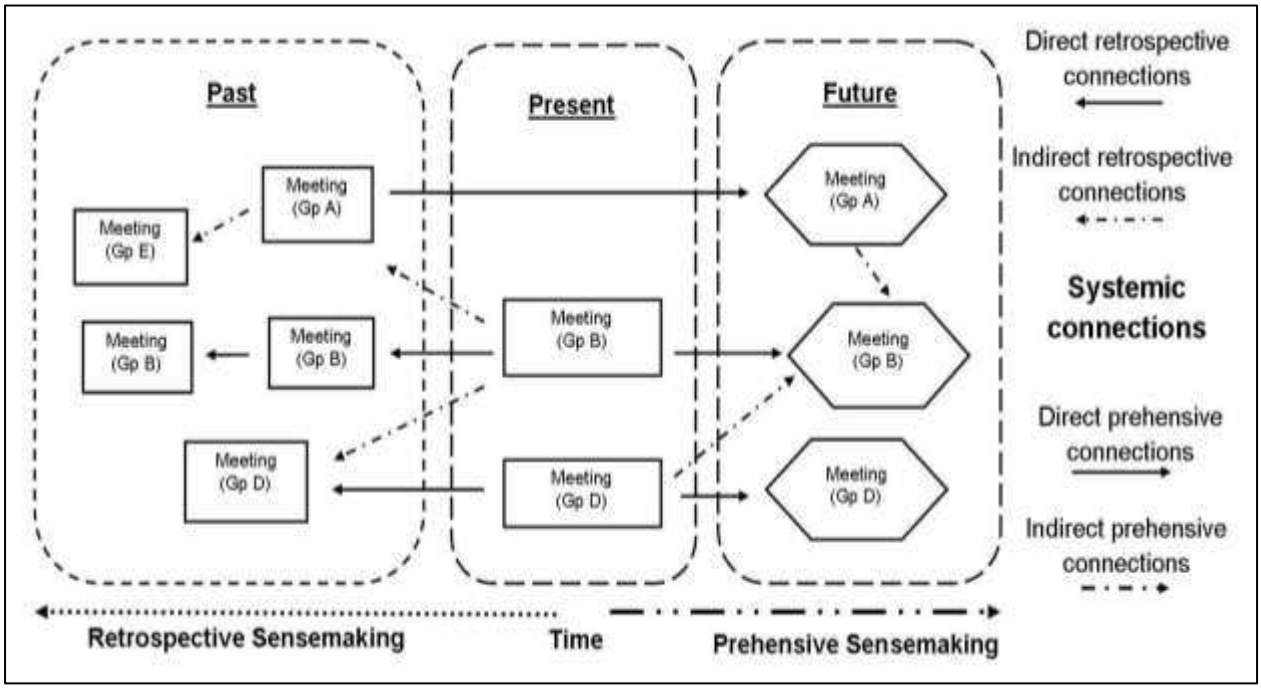

Figure 5 **- Systemic Meetings Model**

The data sample in Exhibit 2 provides an example of direct retrospection in action.

(1:27:55.2) Legal advisor: What {KT-Inc} did two years ago at this board meeting was it decided that it needed to diversify internationally and start a few other things. It also decided that it needed to bring in non-execs onto the board which has been a hugely positive development for the company because .....
Source: KT-Inc Board meeting 15th February 2011

Exhibit 2 - Example of direct retrospection.

In Exhibit 2, the participants did not have any tangible material to refer to or to assist with recalling any specific details and relied solely on the recollections of the legal advisor. This specific historical reference was used by the board to make better sense of the company's current plight in significantly different economic circumstances from those in which the reported conversation took place. These types of retrospective references are made within meetings to help participants make better sense of their current situation, but there is nothing in the data to indicate any structured method for making such connections.

Figure 5 **- Systemic Meetings Model** also shows how meetings of other groups may be referenced by indirect means such as through anecdote from previous meetings or through specific messages being passed from them. Exhibit 3 below illustrates this point - one speaker is trying to make sense of something that occurred in another group's meeting:

(0:16:59.6) Non-Exec director: But it it also] it only mentions the bar coding aspect of the anti-substitution, whereas I thought at the sales meeting [

(0:17:08.6) Marketing Director: it was a bigger thing than that

(0:17:09.6) Non-Exec director:] that it was a much bigger thing and I actually came away from the sales meeting sort of saying to myself that if the only thing we did in 2011 was bring down the level of substitution substantially, it would achieve a huge amount in terms of increasing your sales volumes. But it seems to be getting a relatively low profile on this list.

Source: KT-Inc Board meeting 15th February 2011

Exhibit 3 - Example of indirect retrospection

These connections are labeled 'Indirect Retrospective'. In referencing the sales team meeting the non-executive director also alludes to the transport of such messages from past meetings into present meetings, drawing attention to the modalities of transportation or connection between meetings (Cooren, et al., 2007).

From the Board meeting on the 26th July 2011, Exhibit 4 refers to a product the company had decided to discontinue some six months previously but had not been actioned:

(0:47:30.1) CFO: The I can't really see a future for manufacturing it.
(0:47:33.6) CEO: the only thing is we have picked up a piece of business in the North em eh one hundred thousand pounds a year {product} contract
(0:47:47.6) CFO: With?
Note: CFO refers to Chief Financial Officer
Source: KT-Inc Board meeting 26th July 2011

Exhibit 4 - Absence of systemic connection

This short extract highlights that significant financial developments (a large order for a product that had been scheduled to be discontinued!) were taking place in day to day activities in KT-Inc but the CFO was only becoming aware of them retrospectively during bi-monthly board meetings. The example illustrates that significant activity taking place between meetings, becomes connected through meetings, reinforcing Schwartzman's (1989) contention that meetings are essential loci of organizational sensemaking.

Exhibit 4 also shows a recursive (Giddens, 1984, Introduction xxiii) feature of meetings in that they may act as systemic connectors within the organization's river of discourse, while that same river of discourse itself provides an on-going means of connection between meetings.

In a later board meeting (15th November 2011), after he assumed chairmanship of the Board, the same director made more explicit arrangements (Exhibit 5) to foster direct cross coupling between other group meetings and the Board's meetings:

(0:11:21.4) Board chairman: One of the things that I've talked to {John} and {Mary} about was is bringing eh the heads of the SBUs along to the board meeting and having them sort of account for their stewardship eh give them a half an hour or a forum eh to just provide an overview of where they are eh highlight the achievements em and identify the challenges and the actions that are being taken.

Source: KT-Inc Board meeting 15th November 2011

Exhibit 5 – Extending direct connections between meetings

This illustrates a means to move from previously indirect connections between meeting flows to premeditated and more direct connections with future meetings, for specific purposes.

While sensemaking in meetings is based on retrospection, analysis of the discourse of meeting participants also indicates that sensemaking discussions feed forward into meetings that have not yet taken place, illustrating the concept of prehensive sensemaking discussed previously. The right side of Figure 5 illustrates how prehensive sensemaking is integrated in the evolving SMM. As for retrospective sensemaking, prehensive sensemaking can be both direct and indirect.

Exhibit 6 shows an example of ‘Direct Prehension’ between board meetings;

(3:41:06.5) Board chair: So what are you proposing here, then, that we have a separate meeting of the of the members of the board really senior team to [yea] review the governing objectives here and the strategic imperatives and we'll find new terminology.

(3:41:22.0) CEO: And I don't think we if we want to have it and at the second stage of that is we'll have team meetings with the sales teams em on team initiatives, what we called executive initiatives last year. And we want all that and we want the thing completed by the 01st Nov. We’re going to have to have a separate board meeting for that thing

Source: KT-Inc Board meeting 26th July 2011

Exhibit 6 – Direct and indirect prehensive sensemaking

It should also be noted in Exhibit 6 that the CEO alludes to 'Indirect Prehension' in proposing to continue the process of strategic plan development beyond the next board meeting, by engaging in the future meetings of other strategic business units within the company. There are many examples from the data indicating the intention of participants to inform future meetings in some way from the proceedings of the meeting in which they are currently engaged. However, while awareness is shown of feeding forward into future meetings, there is little or no detail in the discourse of what the exact message(s) should be, who will carry them and how they should be delivered. This could represent an area for more detailed future research associated with a systemic view of meetings.

The SMM provides an overview of how some meetings are connected, based on our empirical analysis of the discourse taking place within meetings. The model identifies four types of connections between meetings - two referencing past meetings termed Direct and Indirect Retrospection, and two projecting interactions with future meetings, termed Direct and Indirect Prehension. The data analysis shows how connections between meetings contribute to sensemaking taking place, but there is no evidence in the data to suggest that meeting participants intended to engage in or to use their meetings collectively, in a systemic way. In spite of the absence of systemic intent for their meetings, a systemic pattern is evident in the various connections arising between meetings and how those connections are sustained over time. In this context, the model represents an abstraction of some of what was happening within meetings collectively in KT-Inc.

At a broader level, the model provides a form of 'roadmap', comprising four types of connections between meetings, which could be used to support a broad review of an organizations meetings and how they relate or could relate to each other. Taken in combination with the various methods of connecting meetings, and applying the concepts of mindfulness and heedfulness, the model provides a means to interrogate how meetings are connected and to consider how such connections could be enhanced or improved. To repeat the words of Weick and Roberts (1993) – "If dispositions toward individual and collective heed were increased in most organizations in conjunction with increases in task-related interdependence and flexibility in the sequencing of tasks, then we would expect these organizations to act more like high-reliability systems." (p. 367). Adopting a more mindful orientation towards using meetings (collectively) as a systemic resource and becoming more heedful of how they are connected as they are taking place, offers the potential to enhance their collective contribution to organizational sensemaking, and by extension to the organization's collective mind.

The relationships between components of a system define its systemic nature. The degree of heedfulness and mindfulness evident within these connections determines the degree to which collective mind is present within a system (Weick & Roberts, 1993). As a final thought on this model it should be remembered that collective mind "…inheres in the pattern of interrelated activities among many people" (Weick & Roberts, 1993, p. 360). The model is not intended to be a prescriptive formulation for meetings but rather a template (McPhee & Zaug, 2000) by which organizational meetings collectively may be identified as an organizational phenomenon constitutive of organization and contributive towards organizational collective mind. The model integrates three concepts as they relate to meetings – sensemaking, heedfulness and mindfulness. The model may serve as a tool to analyze some of the processes of interconnection already in

place between meetings and to prompt ways in which those interconnections may be improved, with a view to enhancing the overall collective mind in the organization. The SMM may help with visualizing the types of connections possible through mechanisms such as trans-participants, immutable mobiles, control-by-proxy and so on as previously described. It may also remind members of one group that valuable connections may be established with meetings of other groups, as much as between the meetings of their own group.

Some Implications for Practice

Since the proposed theoretical perspective on meetings is still being developed, the implications for practice are tentative at this stage. They can be divided into three categories: mindful disposition towards meetings; heedful connections between meetings; and the conduct of meetings.

Mindful Disposition Towards Meetings

Every organization is unique and so too is its use of meetings. An initial implication for practice would require organization members to think differently and act differently in relation to their meetings. A pre-requisite to adopting a systemic approach towards meetings would be the mental shift required to treat meetings as a collective phenomenon rather than as individual, isolated events. Defining a system's purpose is a key feature that identifies it as a system (Checkland & Scholes, 1999; Meadows, 2009). To adopt a systematized approach to meetings would require the purpose of individual meetings, as well as meetings collectively, to be more clearly articulated and adopted in order to realize any systemic benefits that might arise.

If a predisposition was established to use meetings as a systemic resource, it would be possible to set out a 'meetings plan' based on functional areas, organizational activities or any other criteria appropriate to a particular organization. A meetings plan might involve specifying

the dates, sequence, attendees, agenda items etc, but in a way that is coordinated over time, between individual meetings and across meeting flows, rather than just being a schedule of individual events. The deliberate connections to be established between particular meetings and meeting flows could also be identified from the outset. While the specific connections to be made between individual meetings may not be specifiable in advance, the disposition to connect them (mindfulness), and the act of connecting them (heedful interactions) as the meetings occur, may go a long way towards systematizing meetings. Enhanced organizational collective mind may then inhere in the increased interconnections arising from such mindful and heedful disposition towards meetings collectively.

It is not practical to try to connect every meeting to every other meeting, so particular attention could be given to planning specific meeting flows. This would entail identifying particular meeting flows for individual organizations. Figure 6 illustrates three examples of how meeting flows could be conceptualized based on the data from KT-Inc.

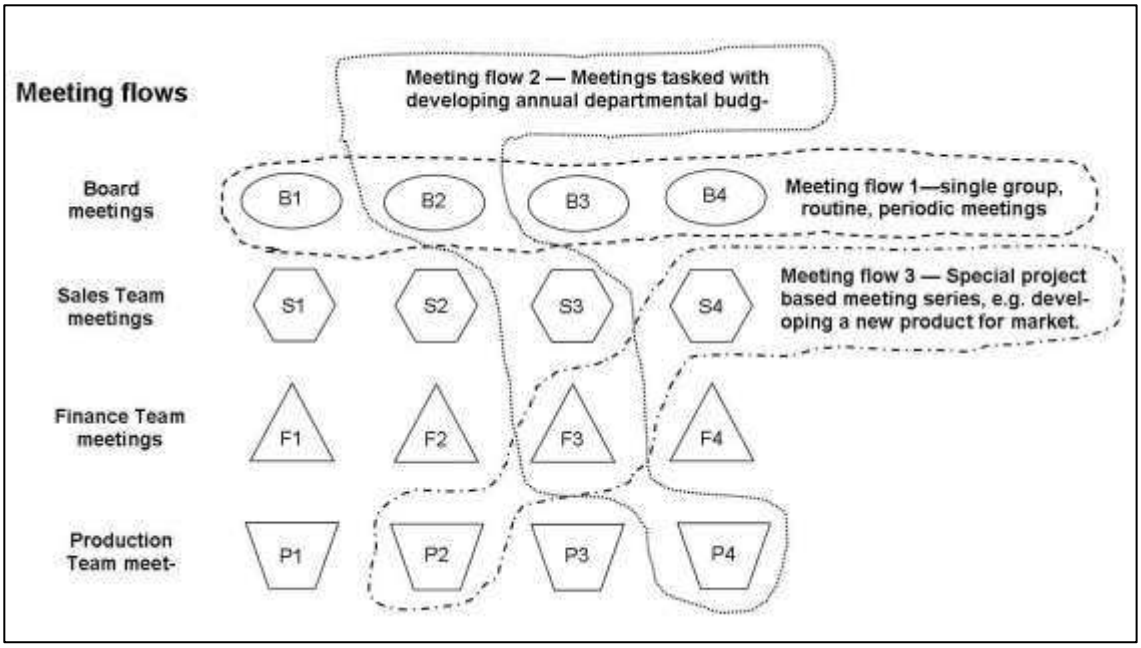

Figure 6 – Meeting flows.

Within certain meeting flows, it may be possible to plan for the outputs from one meeting to be specifically available as inputs to subsequent meetings, which can be mindful action in advance of meetings, even before specific meeting outputs are known. As an example, meetings could be viewed by their function (e.g. as planning events, as information events, as routine update events etc) or alternatively as events for discrete organizational groups to work on specific projects or activities.

Combining the concepts of a meetings plan and meeting flows, a quarterly meeting plan might be prepared and made accessible to specified staff from different functional areas. Such a plan could communicate where specific agenda items will be dealt with, who will be invited, when the meetings will take place (relative to each other) and how outputs/ inputs will be correlated across meetings and time. Once scheduled and published, other parts of the organization may choose to interact with particular meetings that they otherwise would not have been aware of. In this way, the organization's meetings collectively could be mobilized to achieve more than the sum of the individual meetings outputs. Further research would be needed to test this hypothesis, if an organization adopted such a systemic view of its meetings.

Heedfully Connecting Meetings

Adopting a more mindful disposition towards meetings before they happen, with the particular intention of connecting them more explicitly, implies a requirement to focus on how they would then be connected in practice. Our discussion of the various types of connections between meetings provides some resources for practical consideration. For example, focusing on the structure of meeting agendas offers one possibility to create structured connections between meetings. Agendas could be structured using a common format, with agenda items designated under one of five headings, for example – for information; for discussion; for recommendation;

for decision; for action (we pick five for illustration purposes only at this stage). An item designated as ‘for information’ at an early meeting could progress to a ‘for discussion’ item at a later meeting involving more cross functional participants. The same topic could appear later again as a ‘for decision’ item at a meeting whose participants have the specific authority or responsibility to make a final decision on the topic in question. It is worth noting that the topic would be a transient form of connection between meetings but the agenda format as a common artifact would be a more enduring, infrastructural connection between meetings.

An extension of this idea could be an explicit action for every agenda item, to query if the item had been addressed at any other known meetings and what the outcome was. Equal attention could be given to identifying future meetings that the agenda item might be relevant to and any specific message(s) to be conveyed from the present meeting to those future meetings. Consideration would then have to be given to how such messages would be communicated and the role of individuals in such communication.

By deliberately thinking of meetings as connected events, the example above could lead to sequencing of steps to identify more demarcated decision points, within particular meetings or by individuals between meetings. Increased mindfulness of meetings could also ensure issues are brought to the attention of wider groups who may have relevant inputs to make. Meeting minutes could be augmented by specific ‘fit for purpose’ messages about specific topics, to be transmitted to particular future meetings and target audiences.

The concepts identified earlier, such as trans-participants, immutable mobiles, absent participants, control-by-proxy, and temporal markers, provide theoretical foundations on which current practices could be assessed or new practices introduced to achieve the desired outcome of

connecting meetings more explicitly. The detailed activities to be carried out would depend on a large number of variables, many of which would most probably be unique to each organization.

Mindful and Heedful Conduct of Meetings

Adopting a systematized view of meetings would likely require a review of how individual meetings are conducted. With more structured and integrated meeting agendas it may be possible for personnel to attend meetings for specific agenda items of relevance to each individual. A more radical format for attendees might involve free form attendance – meetings could be designated as open or closed to indicate whether individuals could choose to attend.

A quarterly meeting plan, as mentioned previously, would provide notice to other staff of where and when particular topics will be discussed, enabling staff to request permission to attend meetings if they felt they had something to contribute or learn from particular meetings. A further adaptation for meeting participants could be to designate them as either observers or participants, enabling meetings to be used as more focused communicative events within the organizations. Such arrangements already exist in court hearings, certain national parliament meetings or other meetings in wider society, where public galleries are provided to enable freedom of attendance. Where such an idea may be anathema to organizations with closed or secretive cultures, it may be readily achievable in organizations that enjoy more open and participative cultures.

We see many practical possibilities opened up by considering meetings collectively. Any such implications for practice would need to be considered in the cultural and historical context of the organization but certainly could evolve over time if a systemic approach to meetings was implemented in practice. It is beyond the scope of this chapter to assert if any benefits would ultimately accrue from such changes in practice but this might provide an interesting direction

for future research in which meetings are collectively taken as the unit of analysis in organizations that use meetings as a collective and systemic resource.

Conclusion

Systems and process thinking provide an overarching world view (Checkland & Scholes, 1999) that prompts the systemic orientation towards meetings presented in this chapter. By viewing meetings as more than isolated events, a systemic orientation highlights the connections between meetings. Thus a systemic view of meeting in general and the SMM developed in this chapter in particular, also focus the attention of meeting organizers, meeting participants and scholars interested in studying meetings on how such connections are made and the benefits that might arise from them. Where previous research identified meetings as significant loci of organizational sensemaking (Boden, 1994; Schwartzman, 1989), our understanding of prehensive and retrospective sensemaking in the context of organizational meetings provides insights into how meetings are part of a process of collective minding, that contributes to organizational collective mind (Weick & Roberts, 1993). Our Systemic Meetings Model, read in conjunction with modes of connecting meetings such as trans-participants, immutable mobiles, absent participants, control-by-proxy and temporal markers, provides an integrative framework to represent a systemic orientation towards meetings. If the SMM promotes increased mindful and heedful dispositions towards meetings and stimulates improvements in the modes of connection between meetings, then adopting a systemic view of meetings may enhance their contribution to the organizations in which they take place and ultimately help to improve overall organizational effectiveness.

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